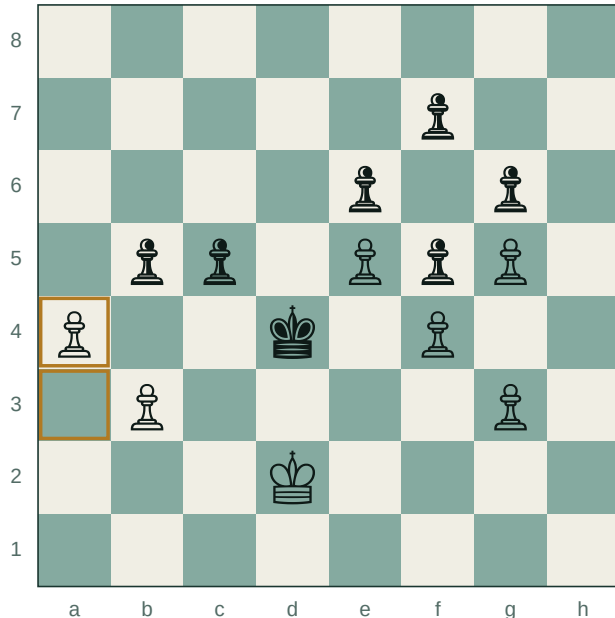


Pawn-ending calculation: Black, move 36

Pawn-ending calculation

Black to move



Previous move: 36.a4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

36...bxa4 37. bxa4 Kc4 38. a5 Kb5 39. Kc3 Kxa5 40. Kc4 Kb6

36...bxa4 The pawn captures the pawn on a4. Recorded reply: **37.bxa4**.

37...Kc4 The king moves from d4 to c4. Recorded reply: **38.a5**.

38...Kb5 The king moves from c4 to b5. Recorded reply: **39.Kc3**.

39...Kxa5 The king captures the pawn on a5. Recorded reply: **40.Kc4**.

40...Kb6 The king moves from a5 to b6.

At the end, nominal material is White 4 / Black 5 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +1. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +1**: the balance goes from +0 to +1. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not enter a pawn ending because it looks simple. Rook-pawn exceptions and zugzwang can make a material advantage irrelevant.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

With only kings and pawns, a single tempo can reverse the result. Calculate opposition, capture routes, promotion races, and reserve pawn moves precisely.

HOW TO LOOK

Count actual king moves and pawn pushes, then include whose turn it is and whether promotion gives check.

The defending king is on d2. Look for a defender that can be displaced or overloaded.